Know The Terms

A Special Education Glossary: The Basics

Special education comes with a lot of acronyms and jargon. This glossary covers the terms you're most likely to hear in meetings and see in documents, explained in plain language.

- **IEP (Individualized Education Program)** - A legally binding document that outlines your child's disability, current performance levels, annual goals, services, placement, and accommodations. It is reviewed and updated at least once per year.
- **IDEA (Individuals with Disabilities Education Act)** - The federal law that guarantees eligible students with disabilities the right to a free, appropriate public education and governs how special education works in the U.S.
- **FAPE (Free Appropriate Public Education)** - Your child's right to receive special education and related services at no cost to your family, designed to meet their unique needs.
- **IEP Team** - The group of people responsible for developing your child's IEP. Required members include you, your child's general and special education teachers, a district representative, and any relevant specialists.
- **Present Levels (PLAAFP)** - The section of the IEP that describes where your child is right now academically and functionally. Everything else in the IEP should build from this.
- **SDI (Specially Designed Instruction)** - Instruction that is adapted in content, method, or delivery to meet your child's unique needs. This is what separates an IEP from a 504 plan.
- **Accommodation** - A change in how your child accesses or demonstrates learning, without changing the standard. Examples include extended time, preferential seating, or larger print.
- **Modification** - A change in what your child is expected to learn or produce. Examples include fewer test questions or an alternate assignment.
- **504 Plan** - A plan under Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act that provides accommodations for students with disabilities who do not qualify for an IEP. It does not include specially designed instruction.

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A Special Education Glossary: Services, Evaluation, & Your Rights

- **Related Services** - Services that support your child's ability to benefit from special education, such as speech-language therapy, occupational therapy, physical therapy, or counseling.
- **LRE (Least Restrictive Environment)** - The requirement that your child be educated alongside non-disabled peers to the maximum extent appropriate for them.
- **ESY (Extended School Year)** - Services provided beyond the regular school year for students who would experience significant regression without them. This is not the same as summer school.
- **Transition Plan** - A component of the IEP required by age 16 that outlines goals and services to support your child's move toward post-secondary education, employment, and independent living.
- **Eligibility** - The determination of whether a student qualifies for special education services under one of the 13 disability categories defined by IDEA.
- **Evaluation** - A comprehensive assessment to determine whether your child is eligible for special education. You must provide written consent before any evaluation takes place.
- **FBA (Functional Behavior Assessment)** - An assessment used to understand why a behavior is occurring, so that an effective BIP can be developed.
- **BIP (Behavior Intervention Plan)** - A written plan, typically attached to an IEP, that outlines strategies to address behaviors that interfere with your child's learning.
- **Prior Written Notice (PWN)** - A written document the school must provide any time it proposes or refuses to take action related to your child's education. This is one of your most important documents - read it carefully.
- **Procedural Safeguards** - Your rights as a parent under IDEA. The school is required to give or offer you a copy at least once per year. They cover everything from consent to dispute resolution.